

A guide to joining the Military: Overexplained Edition.

(Incomplete)

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1. Preface:

While I have done my best to ensure that the information within this document is accurate at the time of publication, defects may still remain. Keep in mind that the contents of this document may become outdated as well—I have no plans on updating it unless I see sufficient merit in doing so. While the scope of this document is more than supplemental, I would advise you to defer to your Recruiter since they have access to more information.

After all, their information is more reliable than mine considering that they're actually in the military. I would strongly recommend that you commit to doing independent research instead of using this publication as your sole source of information to consider joining the military. My goal is to provide information in an impartial manner for those interested in pursuing a military career—not to convince them into joining. Progress was last made in December 2025. As of April 2026, this has been discontinued due to shifting priorities. In the future, I may pick up from where I stopped.

2. Before Joining: Affected Constitutional Rights:

2.1 First Amendment:

Freedom of Speech: You can not criticize your superiors, government officials, or policies as long as you remain a member of the United States Armed Forces. If you do so while in uniform or in public, there's a non-zero probability that your punishment will be more heavy-handed.

Right to assemble: You can not participate in any protests and in any partisan activity while in your official capacity as a member of the United States Armed Forces. The Military is an institution that must remain politically neutral.

Freedom of Press: Your Social Media activity may be subject to military discipline if it violates any military directive. Additionally, all information is tightly regulated, meaning that the disclosure of sensitive information is a criminal offense.

Freedom of Religion: While you retain the ability to practice your religion, it must not interfere with your duties or mission readiness.

2.2 Fourth Amendment:

Your expectation of Privacy is reduced once you join the Military. The Military does not require a warrant to conduct its searches, so a Commanding Officer can order for a search provided that they have probable cause for doing so.

You and the storage facilities that you use on a regular basis can be subjected to regular inspections. Vehicle checks, unit-wise inspections, health & welfare inspections are included as well.

2.3 Fifth Amendment:

Once you join the Military, you are under the jurisdiction of Uniform Code of Military Justice (UCMJ).

A Sovereign is an entity of legal authority that possesses the ability to make and enforce laws independently from any other sovereign. The 5th Amendment has a Double Jeopardy Clause that prevents a Sovereign from prosecuting a person for the same authority twice.

However, the UCMJ, Federal Government, State Government all constitute as Sovereigns. This means that you can be parallelly prosecuted by multiple systems of law for a single offense. For example: If you were found to be drunk driving. The Military can prosecute you under UCMJ Article 111 and hold you accountable to a Court Tribunal and at the same time—the State can prosecute you for your reckless driving.

The Self-Incrimination & Due-Process clauses are in full effect, but work in an altered state due to the Military's internal workings.

Non-Judicial Punishment (NJP) is a military discipline tool that is administrative in its nature. Your Commanding Officer is authorized under UCMJ Article 15 to discipline troops without the need to invoke a formal court-martial. This is applicable for minor infractions that don't require criminal prosecution.

The Military's backbone for Discipline is NJP—court martials are less common.

2.4 Eighth Amendment:

Your Commanding Officer (CO) can order you to do push-ups, “x” miles of jogging along with additional duties or another form of physical activity as a part of Non-Judicial Punishment.

However, the 8th Amendment protects you from cruel and unusual punishments, so while you may be forced to do some exercises—they have to be proportional, safe and reasonable. Your CO has to follow service-specific rules and regulations as each branch has different protocols for this.

2.5 Ninth Amendment:

The 9th Amendment covers all of the rights that are not explicitly mentioned in the Constitution. An example of some of these rights would be: Travel, Marriage, Privacy, Bodily Autonomy, Personal Beliefs, Parental rights, and etc.

However, these rights can be restricted for Military Necessity via UCMJ. For example, you may not be able to travel to certain countries due to travel restrictions. If you want to marry someone, you are obligated to report this to your chain of command. It’s more of a paperwork and documentation hassle as the Military can’t explicitly stop you from marrying someone or travelling anywhere. But, there will be consequences for your actions.

While there are more of your rights that are restricted, they’re less noticeable and are minor in terms of its effects compared to the rights that I have mentioned here. The reason for the restrictions imposed on your rights is to ensure that Military discipline is maintained. This is also applicable to Federal Agencies in a less extreme manner—after all, they are civilians thus the UCMJ does not apply to them. In the place of the UCMJ, internal regulations apply.

The commitment to the Military is oftentimes underestimated due to its trivialization and lack of mention regarding these finer details, so I believe that these restrictions warrant a section.

3. Downsides of joining the Military:

3.1 Restricted Freedom:

You will be more closely monitored and regulated as a member of the United States Armed Forces. This is a matter of consent, as you are not forced to sign the contract to join the

Military. However, once you are bound—it is no longer your choice on whether you stay or not until your contract expires.

You may be prohibited from travelling to certain countries due to your status as a Security Clearance holder or if it serves as a conflict towards your duty. The entire “Affected Constitutional Rights” section is applicable to you the moment you are registered as a Service Member.

3.2 Job Selection:

You may have a dream job that you’re looking forward to getting after joining the Military. Here’s the neat part about the Military, you serve at their behest—which means that if they need a certain job, they will assign it to you regardless of your opinion. So your choice regarding your job isn’t guaranteed which is why you are asked to give multiple preferences for your specific career and area.

3.3 Frequent Relocations:

The Military is structured in a way that you must relocate every now and then. The only choice is similar to how you’re able to select your new location—by making a preference list for the stations that you want to be assigned to. The priorities of the Military come before your own.

3.4 Physical and Mental Health:

While the physical standards aren’t meant to hurt anyone, the regimen is intense and there’s always a risk of injuring yourself from trying to fulfill those standards. Depending on your role, you may be embroiled in combat, so both your mental and physical health have the potential to be severely affected by this.

There’s only the matter of the high expectations that you are held to, along with the continuous performance evaluations. Chronic physical wear & tear that accumulates over the years that you serve for.

Depending on whether you are assigned or deployed to, you may be affected by hazardous chemicals or the environment. You may suffer from PTSD, anxiety, depression or other such mental health conditions as a result of serving.

3.5 Bureaucracy:

I mentioned that some of your rights are restricted but aren't that important. It's due to the fact that it's more of a paperwork issue. Most of the paperwork and documentation you have to do in the military will take some time due to rigid regulations and the cumbersome weight of the Military.

3.6 Disciplinary actions:

Depending on how badly you did in the Military, it has the potential to close many doors in your life since a Dishonourable Discharge is the equivalent of a felony on a background check. An "Other than Honorable", "Bad Conduct Discharge" will also affect your life negatively.

3.7 Education:

Not everything that you're learned in the Military can be translated into a Civilian Format depending on your specific career.

3.8 Lifestyle:

Living in the Military is a more rigid experience, but it's hard for some people to readapt to such a life after serving their nation—there's a reason why Veteran Affairs provides support for people who struggle to readapt to a Civilian Lifestyle. These relocations may place a strain on your personal relationships with others and may reduce access to your support system.

3.9 Deployments:

Even if your career isn't combat-oriented, there's still a chance for you to be deployed to active combat zones or other dangerous locations. Never underestimate the effect that trauma has on your mental landscape.

3.10 Financial:

While the pay is stable and your job security is strong, your salary is oftentimes lower than your civilian counterparts. Your living costs will vary depending on the station that you're assigned to, so your Housing Allowance may not cover all of the rest.

3.11 Promotions:

While your first few promotions are automatic, it's harder to get promoted after that since your personal performance alone won't guarantee it. From there, it depends on openings and evaluations. Some careers have limited advancement opportunities so after a certain point, you may eventually max out your career path.

This is a summary of most, if not all of the downsides of joining the Military. However, some of these downsides are largely mitigated by the benefits of joining the Military which are as follows.

4. Benefits of joining the Military

4.1 Education

The Military will cover the tuition and fees for colleges, vocational schools, and other such programs. It'll also cover housing expenses while in college and will also give you a stipend for books and supplies.

The 9/11 GI Bill has a limit of \$29,920 for Private institutions. For Public Institutions, the Military will only pay for the in-state rate.

This is applicable to both veterans and active duty members. This is applicable for the length of 36 months, with an Honourable discharge if used as a veteran.

Unused benefits can be transferred to dependents if you've served for at least 6 years.

4.1.1 Yellow Ribbon

The Yellow Ribbon is a program under the 9/11 GI Bill that allows the Military to exceed the limit for Private Institutions.

This is only applicable to institutions participating in the Yellow Ribbon program.

Your College will contribute a certain amount of money towards your fees and the Military will match that amount of money, essentially loosening your limits on where you can study without having to worry about debt.

4.1.2 Montgomery GI Bill (Veteran Affairs)

The predecessor to the Post 9/11 GI Bill. While it is more limited in its scope, it provides Service Members a monthly stipend for their education– this is typically used for when money is preferable to tuition coverage.

While you can only benefit from one GI bill at a time, there are nuances that would allow you to benefit from both.

4.2 Accreditation

4.2.1 Enlisted

All of your accumulated experience will be documented with completion certificates or a Joint Services Transcript (JST) [Applicable for the Army, Navy, Marines, Coast Guard]. From there, the American Council on Education will recommend for your experience to be transferred into college credits.

The Air Force and Space Force differ in this regard, as the Air Force is the only branch that has its own college– The Community College of the Air Force (CCAF).

This means that any education that USAF and USSF enlisted receive will have actual college credits that are more transferable to civilian colleges.

The Difference between a JST and CCAF is that a JST recommends credits while the CCAF directly awards you credits.

4.2.2 Officer

Under most cases, this benefit is not applicable for Officers as its purpose was to convert vocational education into civilian equivalents.

It was never built in mind for Officers considering a prerequisite to become one is a Bachelor's Degree from an accredited institution.

However, depending on their speciality field– they may qualify for these benefits. An example of such fields would be medical and cyber as their skills are transferrable to civilian equivalents.

4.3 Professional Military Education (PME)

PME is a structured education system in the Military that is designed to develop leadership, management, and operational skills for Service members.

These courses are a necessary part of your Military life as they will be required for Promotion.

This is primarily a military credential, so there is a high probability for some of these courses to not be considered for college credits.

4.4 Tuition Assurance (TA)

This is only applicable to Service members who are currently active duty unlike the 9/11 GI Bill.

The Military will provide up to a maximum of \$4,500 per year to cover the costs of your education.

This can only be used for tuition and fees. TA does not cover any optional fees which includes transportation and housing. Depending on the branch, you may be able to use TA for books.

4.5 Tuition Assistance Top-Up

This is a bridge between TA and the 9/11 GI Bill and is applicable for when TA alone is not enough for you to pay for your education.

With this, you can use your 9/11 GI Bill benefits to cover fees and tuition that exceeds the limit of TA. For example, if I took a course for \$5000, my TA would first cover \$4500 and then my GI benefit would cover the remaining \$500.

The rules of TA still apply to this, meaning that this can only be used for mandatory fees and tuition.

If Tuition Assistance Top-Up is used, then a dollar-for-dollar deduction will occur for your GI Bill entitlement. This means that I would have \$500 less for my GI Bill entitlement according to the example I made.

4.6 Defense Activity for Non Traditional Education Support (DANTES)

Provides free College-Level Examination Program (CLEP) Exams for Active Duty members. CLEP covers introductory college subjects.

Provides free DANTES Subject Standardized Tests (DSST) for Active Duty members. DSST covers career & technical knowledge from work/military experience and converts it into credits that would accelerate a degree's progression.

Bear in mind that the American Council of Education gives recommendations for awarded credits based on these tests.

This means that you are not directly awarded with credits. Instead, colleges will receive recommendations on the amount of credits that you should receive and decide on accepting them.

4.7 Community College of the Air Force (CCAF)

Apart from the accreditation benefits, Active Duty enlisted members of the Air Force & Space Force may study at CCAF and receive an associates degree of Applied Sciences.

There are multiple categories of specializations for this degree. Once again, Officers are not eligible for this as they already possess a Bachelor's degree related to their commissioning.

4.8 In-House Graduate Schools

The Military has its own Graduate Schools, primarily for their Officers to enroll in to continue their studies.

There are two types of Graduate Schools, branch-specific and Joint/DoD-wide Schools.

A few examples of branch-specific schools are Air Force Institute of Technology (AFIT), Army Command & General Staff College (CGSC), and Naval War College.

DoD-wide schools consist of the following schools: Uniformed Services University of Health Sciences (USUHS), National Intelligence University (NIU), National.

While enrolled in these courses, you will retain all active-duty benefits including pay. However, as an exchange, you will be required to serve additional years in the Military. The cost of these Graduate Schools is time.

4.9 Training Pipelines

Once you have been assigned a speciality, the Military will teach you how to perform your job at a standardized level.

This is more obligatory than a benefit, however it is the fundamentals of your Military Career and is oftentimes practically transferrable— if not formally via other Military programs designed to transfer experience.

This covers both Basic Training and Technical School as you will spend a majority of your first term completing this training pipeline.

4.10 SkillBridge

A DoD program that lets Active Duty Service members do high-demand civilian internships, apprenticeships or job training during their last 180 days of Service.

To be considered eligible for this, you must serve for at least 180 consecutive days before enrolling in this program. Additionally, your separation date must be within 180 days as well.

Furthermore, your internship can be terminated immediately on the grounds of you being required for mission requirements.

5. Financial

5.1 Salary

5.1.1 Base Pay

Your Basic Pay increases with rank and time served. So while you may remain in the same rank for multiple years, your base salary will increase depending on how long you've been with the Military.

If you are stationed outside of your resident state, your Military income is generally exempt from state income tax. However, income from other sources may be liable for state taxes.

5.1.2 Special Pay

This is payment that is added onto your base salary. Not to be confused with allowances, as allowances are oftentimes issued to cover certain expenses.

5.1.2.1 Hazardous Duty Incentive Pay (HDIP)

This is a category of special pay that risks the health and safety of a serviceman in some manner. Some pays are specific to certain roles, such as Flying duty (Crew members & Non-crew members), Parachute duty, diving duty, and etc.

5.1.2.2 Hardship Duty Pay (HDP)

Servicemen performing their duty in a location designated “Hardship duty” by the Military may receive up to \$1,500 monthly. This is usually to compensate for areas that have significantly lower standards of living, not necessarily for combat zones.

These areas often have one of these factors: remote, overseas, extreme climatic conditions or any other factor that significantly affects the standard of living.

5.1.2.3 Hostile Fire/Imminent Danger Pay (HFP/IDP)

A serviceman cannot receive HFP & IDP simultaneously.
Both pay an award of \$225 per month.

5.1.2.4 Imminent Danger Pay (IDP)

Servicemen assigned to an area designated as an Imminent Danger are eligible to receive this special pay.

This is location-based, as the Secretary of Defense is responsible for designating such areas eligible for IDP.

5.1.2.5 Hostile Fire Pay (HFP)

Servicemen at immediate risk of enemy action or under hostile fire are eligible for HFP.

This pay is situation-based with your Commander deciding on whether you are eligible to receive HFP.

5.1.2.6 Foreign Language Proficiency Pay (FLPP)

Servicemen who are certified as proficient in certain languages that the DoD considers as critical.

To be eligible, your branch must first certify your proficiency in that language and it must be on the list that the DoD considers as important.

The maximum that you are entitled is \$12,000 per 1-year certification period. If you do not maintain your certification, you may be obligated to repay some of this pay.

5.1.2.7 Aviation/Fight Pay

This is a category of special pay reserved to servicemen who have a specialty in flight, be it in-person or remotely. This is separate from HDIP that also involves flight.

Aviation Career Incentive Pay (ACIP)

Eligible for Pilots and aircrew members. The purpose of this pay is to retain these servicemen's skills and to reward them for their efforts.

To remain eligible for this special pay, these servicemen must fly on a regular basis.

This may be paid in either lump sum or monthly payment– the maximum monthly payment being \$1,500 and a limit of \$50,000 for a period of 12 months. This depends on rank, years of aviation service, and type of flying.

Flight Duty Pay (FDP)

Eligible to Pilots and aircrew members. This is more of a compensation for being assigned to active flight duty. This is not to be confused with ACIP– ACIP is a retention/reward pay.

To be eligible for this, you must hold a valid flight status and perform actual flight operations– not ground operations.

Payment is monthly, with your rank, years of aviation service and type of flying duty being variables affecting this special pay.

Additional Flight Pay (AFP)

A supplement for FDP for servicemen performing specialized or high-demand duties.

Its purpose is similar to ACIP, however the standard for this special pay is higher.

Only certain roles are eligible for this pay, some examples being Remotely Piloted Aircraft (RPA) Operators, Test Pilots, Specialized crew members, and etc.

Factors that influence this pay are the mission's complexity, aircraft type, years of aviation service and branch-specific policies.

AFP is taxable unlike other incentive pays.

5.2 Entitlements

5.2.1 Travel Pay

When a Permanent change of location (PCS) occurs, the military will reimburse your travel expenses from your old duty station to your new duty station.

If you drive, you get a mileage rate per mile. If you fly, the Military usually covers your ticket.

5.2.2 Travel Per Diem

Reimburses the cost of meals and lodges while you're enroute to your new duty station. While this is typically associated with PCS, this applies to all forms of official Military travel.

Payment is received daily for each authorized travel day.

Lodging and meals are usually included in a single daily rate known as Meals & Incidental Expenses (M&IE). The first and last travel days are paid at 75% of the M&IE rate as you won't travel for the entire day.

Rates vary by location and meals provided by the Military reduce your M&IE rates.

5.2.3 Temporary Lodging Per Diem

Covers temporary lodging and meals at the new duty station until permanent housing is available. Not tied to travel days, this is applied after arrival or temporary housing periods.

This entitlement is usually limited to 10 days for domestic cases. For overseas cases, this limit may be increased.

This pay is treated like an allowance, with pay coming automatically. Occasionally, receipts may be required to receive this payment.

5.2.4 Household Goods Shipment (HHG)

This is a process that occurs during a PCS in which the Military moves your personal belongings from one duty station to another. This ensures that you don't have to pay out of your own pocket for this.

While there are various types of this entitlement, these two types are the most used. Keep in mind that you can use multiple types of this entitlement and combine them.

5.2.4.1 Government-Arranged Move (GAM)

The Military hires professional movers to pack, transport and unload your items.

This includes temporary storage if your new home isn't ready. However, insurance coverage is limited as a result of this.

5.2.4.2 Personally Procured Move (PPM)

You are the one who moves everything instead of the Military doing it for you. In return, the Government will pay you 95% of what it would've paid a contractor to move your items. Additionally, they'll reimburse you for any costs incurred.

You pay with your time as you have to transport it all yourself. You are also assuming full risk for your belongings.

5.2.4.3 Partial PPM

You move some items while the Military moves the rest.

This is often used when your belongings weigh more than what the movers can handle.

It's a hybrid of PPM and GAM so you still benefit from it either way.

5.2.5 Combat Zone Tax Exclusion (CZTE)

If you are deployed to a Combat Zone, your pay is exempt from federal income tax for the period that you remain deployed in that zone. However, some bonuses may still be taxed if they are not linked to your combat service.

5.3 Allowances

5.3.1 Basic Allowance for Housing (BAH)

If a serviceman is not living in government housing, then the Military will provide them with a monthly allowance to cover their living costs.

The size of this allowance depends on rank, dependent status, and duty location.

The BAH for different locations varies due to the different costs of living, so it may increase or decrease from your last assignment.

If you have dependents, you will receive a higher amount of BAH.

BAH is tax-exempt for both federal and state income taxes.

If you live on a Military base or some form of government quarter, you will not receive BAH.

Additionally, you are not obligated to spend your entire allowance. You can pocket the remainder. So the amount of money you actually get to keep depends on your frugality.

5.3.2 Basic Allowance for Subsistence (BAS)

This is a monthly allowance for a Serviceman's food costs.

This is an automatic allowance, meaning that you will receive it whether you are on-base or not. However, its usage depends on where you eat.

Enlisted Servicemen receive more than their Officer counterparts since the Military assumes that the Officers generally have more disposable income. After all, the enlisted have more need for it.

If you reside in base, then you may eat from the mess hall or the Officer's mess (Officer-only). Your BAS would be used to cover the costs, so think of it being applied directly. Your food is technically free that way.

If you live off-base or elect to eat outside, then you will directly receive the cash so you can go outside and eat. Similar to BAH, you may pocket the remainder of this allowance, so it depends on you.

5.3.3 Uniform Allowance

The Military provides its servicemen with an annual allowance to cover the costs of their uniform, insignia and other required clothing articles.

This is dependent on rank as Enlisted receive more as their uniforms often wear out more, thus requiring them to purchase more standardized uniforms.

Once again, Officers receive less as their uniforms are usually high quality and they are expected to maintain their own wardrobe. They may receive a special allowance for certain uniforms if required.

5.3.4 Family Separation Allowance

If you are assigned or deployed to an area that your family is unable to accompany you, then the Military will compensate you with an allowance.

This allowance is a monthly \$250, a uniform rate that ignores factors like Rank.

This Allowance is applicable if you are assigned or deployed to that area for over 30 days. Additionally, if your family has the capability to move with you but decides not to, then you do not qualify for this allowance.

This is only applicable for you if your family cannot actually move with you for valid reasons.

5.3.5 Cost of Living Allowance (COLA)

5.3.5.1 Outside the Continental United States- Cost of Living Allowance (OCONUS COLA)

The Military provides a monthly allowance to its servicemen who are either assigned or deployed abroad. The purpose of this allowance is to offset the living costs of these Countries.

This monthly allowance is calculated with your dependent status and location. Rank has little effect on this allowance.

5.3.5.2 Continental United States– Cost of Living Allowance (CONUS COLA)

This allowance is to supplement the living costs of Servicemen who have been assigned to high-cost areas within the United States.

An area is considered high cost if the non-housing cost of living for that area exceeds a threshold of 107%.

This is only applicable to members assigned to duty stations where the non-housing cost of living is at least eight percent above the national average.

Housing costs are considered a part of BAH, so it's excluded from CONUS COLA.

Your paygrade is factored into these calculations as this allowance is to act as a supplement.

5.3.6 Overseas Housing Allowance (OHA)

The abroad variant of BAH for servicemen who are assigned or deployed outside of the United States.

Rent is covered along with Maintenance and Insurance (If required). There may be a chance that your utilities will also be covered by this allowance.

OHA is calculated with your Rank, location, and dependent status.

5.3.7 Dislocation Allowance (DLA)

The Military will cover the miscellaneous costs of moving. This is typically given when a permanent location change (PCS) occurs. As some costs don't fit into the Military's system, this is meant to offset those costs.

You are paid with a one-time lump sum payment.

5.4 Retirement

5.4.1 Traditional Military Retirement

A retirement plan that guarantees monthly income for life after completing twenty years of service.

It was the default retirement plan for service members before 2018. Servicemen can opt-in to this retirement plan within 12 months of their joining.

This pension is calculated with the High-36 formula. This formula takes the average of the highest 36 months of your base pay and multiplies it with your years of service. This retirement has a 2.5% multiplier for every year of service.

To clarify, High-36 refers to the highest 36 months of your base pay. This tends to be the last three years before you retire as they're the highest paying months.

To sum it up, the formula= $2.5\% \times (\text{Years of Service}) \times (\text{Average of High-36})$

Example: You served for 25 years, your base pay for the last four years was \$5,000.

Pension = $2.5\% \times 20 \times 5000$

Pension= \$2500 per month.

This is ideal for people who intend on having a full career in the Military, since it's either 20 years or nothing with this plan.

5.4.2 Thrifts Savings Plan (TSP)

A TSP is the federal government's equivalent of a 401K.

This benefit is restricted to Servicemen, Federal Civilian employees, and certain federal groups.

Like 401Ks, traditional TSP and Roth TSP exist and work similarly to their civilian counterparts.

The TSP is unique in a few respects. For starters, it has one of the lowest fees and expense ratios. It has lifecycle funds— funds that automatically adjust for risk.

Additionally, the Government matches your contributions— breaking away from their norm of defined-benefits contributions.

They'll automatically contribute 1% of your base pay monthly even if you contribute nothing. You can contribute 5% in which the Government will match the first 3% entirely. For the remaining 2%, they will contribute half of that amount.

Your contributions are automatically yours with the Government immediately vesting their contributions to you as well. The automatic 1% is vested after 2 years.

This is integrated with the BRS for the Military.

5.4.3 Blended Retirement System (BRS)

A hybrid military retirement plan that was first introduced in 2018 and is now the default plan for servicemen.

It has three components to it, the first being a smaller defined-benefit pension and the second being a defined contribution savings plan using your TSP. The third component is Continuation pay (CP).

The pension component works similarly to the traditional retirement system. You'll start getting a pension after 20 years of service and it'll be calculated with the same formula. However, your multiplier will be 2%, less than the traditional plan's 2.5%.

The TSP is already integrated into this system. This means that once you are enrolled in the BRS, the government will start your TSP with 5% of your base pay to give you the maximum possible federal match.

Continuation Pay is a one-time mid career bonus offered to Servicemen in exchange for them serving for additional years. This is only applicable to Servicemen under the BRS plan.

This bonus is calculated as a multiple of your base pay. An example being 5x of your monthly base pay. Your branch decides this multiplier.

You typically will receive this bonus between 8-12 years of service, but your branch will decide the entire year.

Rank has an indirect effect since base pay is correlated to it. Additionally, there may be some differences between officers and enlisted.

5.5 Bonuses

One-time or lump sum payments used to recruit or retain personnel in critical skills, roles, or career stages.

5.5.1 Enlistment Bonus

This is eligible for enlisted personnel only as Officers have their own bonuses. The purpose of this bonus is to attract recruits for high-demand or critical jobs.

This is paid as a lump-sum or split into multiple payments. The amount depends on your branch, job and length of enlistment.

It is paid after Initial training or at specified intervals.

5.5.2 Officer Retention Bonuses

This is only eligible for Officers– depending on their specific field. The purpose of this bonus is to retain these Officers as their skills are both expensive and critical.

Some examples of these bonuses are Medical Bonuses, Cyber Bonuses, Nuclear Officer Bonuses, etc.

This is either paid as a lump-sum payment or annual retention pay for agreeing to serve additional years.

6. Healthcare

6.1 Healthcare System (MTF and Tricare)

The Military's Healthcare system has two main components to it.

6.1.1 Military Treatment Facilities (MTFs)

MTFs are the healthcare facilities owned, staffed, and operated by the Dept. of Defense. Servicemen are first referred to these facilities on-base– functioning as hospitals.

The services provided by this MTF is dependent on its size. Larger MTFs oftentimes have the ability to provide care for the full spectrum of healthcare while smaller facilities may only have Primary Care and a few specialities.

This form of treatment is free for all servicemen.

6.1.2 Tricare

Tricare is the Military’s comprehensive health insurance program for active duty members, retirees, and their families.

This is free for active duty members. Families and retirees have to pay a small premium – oftentimes lower than civilian counterparts.

It’s comprehensive and works with both Military treatment facilities (MTFs) and civilian providers.

This insurance network is oftentimes used when a MTF does not have the ability to treat the Serviceman– serving as a way to supplement the Military’s healthcare and to ensure that there are no gaps.

This service is free for Servicemen with the Military reimbursing them for their travel expenses. All Servicemen are enrolled into TRICARE Prime by default.

6.2 Preventive Healthcare

6.2.1 Annual Health Assessments

The Military will make you undergo a variety of physical and health tests each year for the sake of troop readiness. This would allow you to discover any underlying conditions earlier as it’s conducted yearly.

6.2.2 Immunization Programs

All Servicemen receive Influenza, Tetanus-diphtheria-pertussis (Tdap), MMR, Varicella, Hepatitis A & B, COVID (if required).

6.2.3 Deployment-related Health Preparations

Servicemen who are being deployed abroad may receive additional vaccinations specific to the area of deployment. They will receive pre-deployment health screenings to catch any hidden conditions as troop readiness must be maintained.

Additionally, you get follow-up screenings post-deployment with an emphasis on mental conditions. This is usually done months after deployment is over to catch any delayed conditions

6.3 Special Medical Surveillance

6.3.1 Periodic Exams

If your job exposes you to hazards, you will receive periodic special exams. This can include Audiology tests, Spirometry, blood toxin monitoring, and other related tests.

6.3.2 Job-specific Testing

Any job that requires a certain standard of a physical sense will also receive more frequent testing and screening. Aviation-related jobs receive yearly hearing tests, vision exams, and occasional colour vision tests.

Hearing tests are administered to combat-oriented jobs after exposure to loud noises via heavy weapons or blasts. The jobs that I have mentioned are examples, as I cannot cover all of the jobs that have this layer of scrutiny.

6.4 Physical Training (PT) Programs

While the Military expects you to abide by certain physical standards– it will give you the resources to maintain them.

6.4.1 Official PT Time and Facilities

The military will give you official duty time for physical training. This allotted time would be in the morning and is counted as a part of your workday.

6.4.2 Free Access to Gyms and Fitness Classes

Servicemen have free access to the on-base gyms and other fitness facilities. A few examples of these facilities would be 24/7 Base fitness centers, weight rooms, tracks, and more. Additionally, there's also fitness classes for you to join like martial arts, yoga, ruck training, etc.

6.4.3 Lifestyle Support

The base itself has exercise physiologists, strength coaches and other professional staff members to assist you. Special operation units have an upgraded version of this due to their standards being higher.

Medical and Physical therapy are free, allowing you to recover from any injuries sustained during PT. There are remedial programs for Servicemen who fail a physical test, designed to get them back into standard.

There is also support regarding nutrition— with meal planning and dietitians. These benefits are dependent on three factors. Your base, unit, and branch.

6.5 Environmental Exposure Registries

6.5.1 Tracking Hazard Exposures (Deployment, Occupational)

The Military tracks and records every instance that you are exposed to a hazard in its registries. This is more commonly seen in

While these registries alone may not constitute a proper benefit, it has the potential to affect all of your other benefits. This is especially true for Veteran Affairs-related benefits.

As these registries are used as partial proof for a disability claim— which may in turn extend some of your benefits post-military. The scope of each registry is narrow, often being tied into certain events or deployments— focusing on exposures, not the resultant conditions.

6.5.2 Impact on Disability Claims and Veteran Benefits

It is made with self-reported submissions as the norm— exceptions exist where the Military actively recorded and categorized a certain registry.

If your exposure is not covered in an official registry, then it will make it harder for your disability-claim to check through.

This information was compiled with the intent of it being applicable to all branches, which is why I didn't go into the specifics for some branches. Additionally, some benefits come in other sub-categories but I omitted them to reduce redundancy. An example of this being the omission of Continuation Pay from the Bonuses subsection.